

Phase 2 marks the start of systematic phonic work. It begins the introduction of grapheme-phoneme correspondences (GPCs). Decoding for reading and encoding for spelling are taught as reversible processes. As soon as the first few correspondences have been learned, children are taught to blend and segment with them. Blending means merging individual phonemes together into whole words; segmenting is the reverse of splitting up whole spoken words into individual phonemes.

Earlier, in Phase 1, blending and segmenting activities have been purely oral, involving no letters, for example, an adult pronounces the sounds to be blended rather than expecting the children to pronounce them in response to letters. In Phase 2, however, the children learn to pronounce them in response to letters, before blending them, and thus start reading simple VC and CVC words. The reverse process is that they segment whole spoken words into phonemes and select letters to represent those phonemes, either writing the letters, if they have the physical coordination, or using magnetic letters to encode words.

This systematic, high quality phonic work is best taught in short, discrete daily sessions, with ample opportunities for children to use and apply their phonic knowledge and skills throughout the day. Right from the start, however, every child will need to experience success moving incrementally from the simple to the more complex aspects of phonics work. Phase 2 therefore starts with the tried and tested approach to learning a selection of letters (s a t p i n) and emphasises multi-sensory activity.

Children entering Phase 2 will have experienced a wealth of listening activities, including songs, stories and rhymes. They will be able to distinguish between speech sounds and many will be able to blend and segment words orally. Some will be able to recognise spoken words that rhyme and will be able to provide a string of rhyming words, but inability to do this does not prevent moving on to Phase 2 as these speaking and listening activities continue.

The purpose of this phase is to teach at least 19 letters, and move children on from oral blending and segmentation to blending and segmenting with letters. By the end of the phase many children should be able to read some VC and CVC (consonant vowel consonant) words and to spell them using either magnetic letters or by writing letters on paper or whiteboards. During the phase they will be introduced to reading two-syllable words and simple captions. They will also learn to read some Common Exception Words.

Letter Progression

Phase 2 – Letter Sounds

s	a	t	p	i	n	m	d
g	o	c	k	ck	e	u	r
h	b	f	ff	l	ll	ss	